

SANTA BARBARA

THE MAGAZINE OF SANTA BARBARA COUNTY

Discovery:
The Source of the
Chumash Magic Stones

Chris Mitchum
Makes His Own Way

How Santa Barbara
Throws Its Biggest Party

A Gringo's Guide
to Mexican Food

**HORSE
COUNTRY**

in Santa Barbara County



While pursuing the archaeological mystery of the magic stones on San Nicolas Island, our team—consisting of Klope, Conti, Al-

len and myself—decides to investigate a cavern known as the Cave of the Whales. Sometime in the distant past, the Nicoleños adorned the walls of this huge cavern with numerous paintings and carvings. We are aware that time and the ele-



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has been cut into the stone at the other side of the cave's entrance. Nor are all the images on the cave's walls petroglyphs. Many pictographs

—painted images—have also survived.

Surrounded by figures of leaping dolphins and killer whales, we begin to explore every detail of the cave. Although we had first thought the cave interior drab and colorless, our high-intensity lights reveal light green algae covering the surface of the ceiling. I notice a harbor seal skull stashed deep in a crevice, possibly left by some unknown artist to gnaw on as a snack. (The Lone Woman was in the habit of caching seal bones as reserve food supplies.)

At the head of the cave I see a small hole just big enough for a person to squeeze through. Beyond the opening, the sandy floor of a long tunnel stretches into the distance. I clamber in, hoping to find more native rock art.

After wriggling on my belly for some twenty feet, I come to the end of the tunnel. I can see no paintings or inscriptions. Rolling over to look at the low ceiling, I suddenly notice something moving.

The ceiling is alive with spiders.

Black widows and dark brown spiders of all sizes have taken a liking to the spot. Dusty strands of web festoon the rock, hanging like Spanish moss. I don't linger there long.

Back in the main cavern, all the fearsome sea creatures seem like old friends.

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The Cave of the Whales



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ments have also left their mark on sections of the cave. Before the images are lost forever, we intend to photograph all the remaining rock art.

As we enter the 40-feet-deep cave, we notice, chipped into rock, a shark-like figure that guards the entrance. Inside, on the cave's walls, other petroglyphs—images carved into stone—depict various sea creatures. Dolphins, killer whales, sharks, swordfish—the strange etchings suggest many different interpretations. One figure even looks like a goldfish.

Whatever these figures may have represented to the Nicoleños, nearly all of them possess tall dorsal fins. These images prompted the researchers who first documented the cave in the late 1950s to name the spot the Cave of the Whales.

Not all of the art in the cave represents marine animals: a double sawtoothed line



GLENN B. ALLEN

A petroglyph—rock carving—of a three-masted schooner sails across the sandstone on lonely San Nicolas Island, top. Above left, a double sawtoothed line adorns the entrance of the Cave of the Whales. Above, the magic stone team painstakingly photographs each wall of the cave. Below, pictographs—painted images—of dolphins or killer whales leap across the rock walls inside the cavern.



The Cave of the Whales

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Perhaps these animals were friends to the Nicoleños; to some tribes, such animals were deities. At any rate, I doubt that the renderings represent hunting activities since no weapons are depicted.

After exploring the cave, our group hikes to a remote beach to examine a different example of native art—a three-masted schooner carved into a flat sandstone rock. This petroglyph emerged when a sand dune shifted less than two years ago. The vessel seems to float on a wavy line incised below it. Behind the schooner is the nearly obliterated image of another vessel. Behind this vessel, another wavy line suggests the sea.

Who made the carving? An Indian or a European? I doubt that the artist was a European because Europeans rarely left representational images. Instead they favored to carve their initials and a date as a record of their visit. But to the Nicoleños, the vision of a huge sailing ship, especially a first sighting, could well have seemed a supernatural event. For that matter, the carving could represent a shipwreck, which would have seemed like a visit from another world to the islanders.

Indeed, history indicates that in 1824—before the Nicoleños were removed from the island—the schooner *John Begg* stranded on a rock that lies a short distance from the west end of San Nicolas. Could the carving have been a means of

recording this event?

I wonder if the Lone Woman made the carvings, for she had every reason to place importance on the passing of each ship. Moreover, legend has it that she did record passing ships, although the story goes that she left her record in a cave.

The identity of the artist who carved the ship petroglyph and the significance of the Cave of the Whales may remain mysteries of windswept San Nicolas. But these images remind us that no matter where we go on the island, the presence of the Nicoleños is with us. From the darkest cave to the most remote beach, we are never alone. Despite the ravages of time and change, the Nicoleños will not be forgotten. —P.C.H.

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PLEASE,
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ZACK'S!



Betty Mazzetti Hatch, model/talent agency owner, applauds Zack's Broiled Swordfish filled with smoked salmon cream cheese.

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Zack's
AT THE BEACH

Fine American Regional Cuisine.